

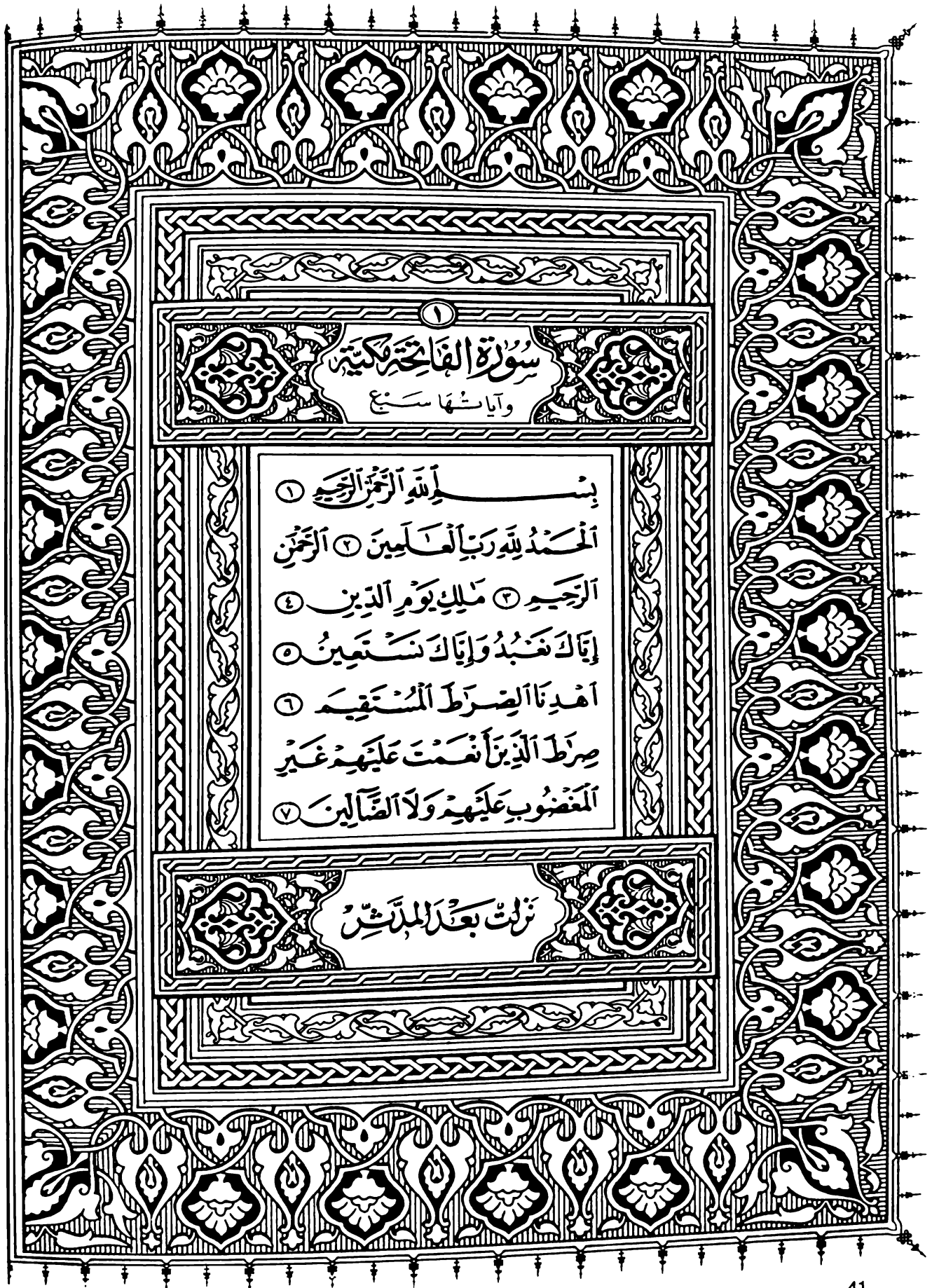
English Meanings of the Qur'an : 1

A true understanding of Islam requires, as a minimum, a reasonable understanding of its message, the Qur'an. While many people acquire a distorted picture of the religion by observing some aspects of the actions, history, or personal conduct of its professed followers, the readers of this series are presented with an opportunity to grasp the basic principles of true Islam. Readers who are familiar with the various Qur'anic translations will appreciate the fact that this is the first English rendering of the Qur'an's meanings by a Muslim Arab. It is being printed for the first time.

Sura Al-Fātiḥah (The Opener) 1:1-7

Sura 1
Al-Fātiḥah (The Opener)
REVEALED IN MECCA

1 In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful. 2 Praise be to God, the Lord of all beings, 3 The Compassionate, the Merciful, 4 Master of the day of judgment. 5 Only You do we worship, and only You do we implore for help. 6 Guide us along the right path, 7 The path of those upon whom You bestow Your grace; not of those who incur indignation, nor of the strayers.



سُورَةُ الْفَاتِحَةِ مَكِّيَّةٌ

وآيَاتُهَا سَبْعٌ

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ ①
الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ رَبِّ الْعَالَمِينَ ② الرَّحْمَنِ
الرَّحِيمِ ③ مَلِكِ يَوْمِ الدِّينِ ④
إِيَّاكَ نَعْبُدُ وَإِيَّاكَ نَسْتَعِينُ ⑤
اهْدِنَا الصِّرَاطَ الْمُسْتَقِيمَ ⑥
صِرَاطَ الَّذِينَ أَنْعَمْتَ عَلَيْهِمْ غَيْرِ
الْمَغْضُوبِ عَلَيْهِمْ وَلَا الضَّالِّينَ ⑦

نَزَلَتْ بَعْدَ الْمَدَنِيِّ

ENGLISH MEANINGS OF THE QUR'AN : 1

Furthermore, the word "*Al-Raḥmān*" is an exclusive name of God which equals the name "*Allāh*" in every respect. Why then should we translate "*Al-Raḥmān*," and not "*Allāh*?" The same principle applies to the divine name "*Al-Raḥīm*."

The practice of partially translating "*Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm*," and using the Arabic (but not necessarily Islamic) word "*Allāh*" without translation, has led to a number of unfortunate misunderstandings. One such misunderstanding is the impression upon certain people, especially those accustomed to deification of human beings, that "*Allāh*" is the name of a man. Even highly respectable circles, such as Webster's Dictionaries, were led to believe that "*Allāh*" is the "Supreme Being of the Muslims" (2). *Allāh*, of course, is "THE GOD" of all beings, whether they realize it or not.

The Source of Anger

Sura *Al-Fātiḥah*, as the reader realizes, is generally self-explanatory. The last verse, however, has been invariably mistranslated. Thus, most translators, if not all of them, have erroneously identified the source of "*ghaḍab* غَضَبٌ," i.e., anger, or wrath, or indignation, to be God Almighty (3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8). The term "*ghayril maghḍūbi 'alayhim* غَيْرِ الْمَغْضُوبِ عَلَيْهِمْ," however, does not identify the source of anger. The source of anger or indignation incurred by the sinners could be God, the angels, or the people. Whatever the case may be, the source of anger is *NOT* identified in sura *Al-Fātiḥah*. Putting this fact in perspective may be significant for those who wish to study the question, "Is anger a quality of God?"

chance of coincidence highly unlikely, and confirms that the opening statement is not exogenous to the divine revelation.

3. Aside from the observations on the first and the last suras, one sura in the middle of the Qur'an deliberately omits the opening statement "In the name of God . . ." As mentioned above, this one sura is *Al-Tawbah* (No. 9).

While "*Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm*" is the first verse of *Al-Fātiḥah*, it is not assigned a specific number in the other suras. In the humble opinion of this commentator, the opening statement, "In the name of God," takes on the number of any verse wherever we start a Qur'anic recitation. Thus, when we recite any sura, with the exception of *Al-Tawbah* (No. 9), the opening statement, "In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful," becomes part of the first verse if we start the recitation at the beginning of the sura; it becomes part of verse number 15 if we start the recitation at verse 15, and so forth. Since the opening statement is shown to be an integral part of each sura (except *Al-Tawbah*), this discussion emphasizes that it must be included whenever we recite the Qur'an. When the recitation is not part of a ṣalāt prayer, Muslims are enjoined to begin the recitation with a statement whereby they ask God's protection from the influence of Satan (Qur'an 16:98).

God vs. Allāh

Some translators have apparently considered the word "Allah" to be *the* proper name of God in Islam. Consequently, they did not translate this "name" into other languages. According to them, the opening words "*Bismillāh*" are rendered into "in the name of Allah." However, the word "Allāh" is not *THE* Islamic name of God, as erroneously believed by some. It is merely the Arabic counterpart of the English words "the God." The syllable "*Al*" in the word "Allāh" means "the." A god or a deity is called "*ilāh*" in the Arabic language. Thus, the words "the God" would be equivalent to the Arabic "*Al-ilāh*," which is rather awkward phonetically. To overcome this awkwardness, the Arabs simply dropped the letter "i" from "*Al-ilāh*," which made it "Allāh." The literal translation of the word "Allāh," therefore, would be "The God." Support for the statement that "Allah" is not necessarily *THE* Islamic name of God comes from the fact that all Arabs use this word, regardless of their religion, to mean God. Additionally, the word "Allāh" has been used in pre-Islamic Arabia. The Prophet's father, for example, was named "Abdullāh (servant of God)."

Translating "*Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm*" into "In the name of Allāh, the Compassionate, the Merciful" constitutes an incomplete translation.

COMMENTARY

This sura, properly entitled "The Opener," was the first sura revealed in its entirety. It was described by the prophet Muḥammad (may God bestow blessings and peace upon him) as "the essence of the Qur'an = *ummul Kitāb* = أُنْزِلَ الْكِتَابُ." This description can be appreciated if we recount the major Islamic principles which are stated in this short sura. Thus, in the seven verses of *Al-Fātiḥah* we are told:

1. To believe in God; that He is One.
2. That God is characterized by compassion and mercy.
3. That God is the Lord, cherisher, and sustainer of all beings.
4. That there shall be a day of judgment, hence resurrection and the eternal hereafter.
5. That only God deserves to be worshiped; He alone is capable of helping us.

The importance of *Al-Fātiḥah* is manifested in the fact that all Muslim men and women are enjoined to recite it a minimum of 17 times per day as part of the ṣalāt prayers.

The Opening Statement

The opening statement "*Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm* = In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful" precedes every sura in the Qur'an with one exception, namely, sura *Al-Tawbah* (Repentance) (No. 9). There is a general consensus among the leading *mufasssirs* (Qur'anic commentators) that this statement is an integral part of each sura (except *Al-Tawbah*). This is supported by a number of observations:

1. The opening statement constitutes the first verse of the first sura. In a strongly documented *Ḥadīth*, the prophet Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him) specifically designated *Bismillāhir Raḥmānir Raḥīm* as the first verse of *Al-Fātiḥah* (Al-Bukhārī, Muslim).
2. Recent computerized analysis of the alphabetical structure of the Qur'an (1) has provided new and conclusive evidence to supplement the already convincing historical evidence and prophetic traditions. The physical evidence indicated by the computerized study shows clearly that each letter in the Qur'an's composition was accurately and deliberately calculated. For example, computed without excluding the opening statement "*Bismillāh . . .*" the final sura of the Qur'an, *Al-Nās*, was found to consist of 99 alphabetic letters — the same number as God's ninety-nine magnificent names. The fact that this particular number of alphabetic letters does not occur in any other sura but the closing sura renders the

Sura Al-Baqarah (The Heifer) 2:1-29

Sura 2
Al-Baqarah (The Heifer)
REVEALED IN MEDINA

In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful
1 A.L.M. 2 This scripture is without a doubt; providing
guidance for the righteous, 3 Who believe in the unseen,
observe the *ṣalāt* prayers, and from My provisions to them
they spend. 4 They believe in what was sent down to you
(O Muḥammad), and in what was sent down before you,
and they firmly believe in the hereafter.

سُورَةُ الْبَقَرَةِ مَكِّيَّةٌ

وآياتها ٢٨٦

بِسْمِ اللَّهِ الرَّحْمَنِ الرَّحِيمِ
الْحَمْدُ لِلَّهِ الَّذِي لَمْ يُتَّخَذْ فِيهِ
مُشْرِكٌ مُبِينٌ ۝ الَّذِينَ يُؤْمِنُونَ
بِالْغَيْبِ وَيُقِيمُونَ الصَّلَاةَ وَمِمَّا
رَزَقْنَاهُمْ يُنفِقُونَ ۝ وَالَّذِينَ
يُؤْمِنُونَ بِمَا أُنزِلَ إِلَيْكَ وَمَا أُنزِلَ
مِنْ قَبْلِكَ وَبِالْآخِرَةِ هُمْ يُوقِنُونَ ۝

وَمِنْ أَوَّلِ سُورَةِ نَزَلَتْ بِالْمَدِينَةِ

5 Such are the followers of guidance from their Lord. Such are the winners.

6 As for those who disbelieve, it is the same for them; whether you warn them or not, they do not believe. 7 God seals their hearts, and their hearing, and their visions are veiled. Theirs is a grievous punishment. 8 And there are those who say, “We believe in God and the hereafter,” while they are not believers. 9 In attempting to deceive God and the believers, they deceive only themselves, without perceiving. 10 In their hearts is skepticism. Consequently, God augments their skepticism. Theirs is a painful punishment for their lying. 11 When they are told, “Do not corrupt the earth,” they say, “We are but reformers.” 12 Indeed, they are the corruptors, but they do not perceive. 13 And when they are told, “You shall believe as the people have believed,” they say, “Shall we believe as the fools have believed?” Indeed, it is they who are fools, but they do not know. 14 Whenever they meet the believers, they say, “We believe.” But when alone with their devils, they say, “We are with you. We were only mocking.” 15 God mocks them by allowing them to continue their transgressions blindly. 16 These have traded away guidance for straying. Thus, their trade never profits, nor do they find guidance. 17 Their allegory is like one who kindles a fire to provide light. As it begins to shed light around him, God takes away their light, leaving them in total darkness, unable to see. 18 Deaf, dumb, and blind; they fail to reform.

أُولَئِكَ عَلَى هُدًى مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ وَأُولَئِكَ هُمُ الْمُفْلِحُونَ ٥ إِنَّ الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا سَوَاءٌ عَلَيْهِمْ أُنذِرْتَهُمْ أَمْ لَمْ تُنذِرْهُمْ لَا يُؤْمِنُونَ ٦ خَتَمَ اللَّهُ عَلَى قُلُوبِهِمْ وَعَلَى سَمْعِهِمْ وَعَلَى أَبْصَارِهِمْ غِشَاوَةٌ وَلَهُمْ عَذَابٌ عَظِيمٌ ٧ وَمِنَ النَّاسِ مَن يَقُولُ ءَامَنَّا بِاللَّهِ وَبِالْيَوْمِ الْآخِرِ وَمَا هُمْ بِمُؤْمِنِينَ ٨ يُخَذِّلُونَ اللَّهَ وَالَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا وَمَا يُخَذِّلُونَ إِلَّا أَنْفُسَهُمْ وَمَا يَشْعُرُونَ ٩ فِي قُلُوبِهِمْ مَرَضٌ فَزَادَهُمُ اللَّهُ مَرَضًا وَلَهُمْ عَذَابٌ أَلِيمٌ ١٠ كَانُوا يَكْذِبُونَ ١١ وَإِذَا قِيلَ لَهُمْ لَا تُفْسِدُوا فِي الْأَرْضِ قَالُوا إِنَّمَا نَحْنُ مُصْلِحُونَ ١٢ أَلَا إِنَّهُمْ هُمُ الْمُفْسِدُونَ وَلَكِن لَّا يَشْعُرُونَ ١٣ وَإِذَا قِيلَ لَهُمْ ءَامِنُوا كَمَا ءَامَنَ النَّاسُ قَالُوا أَنُؤْمِنُ كَمَا ءَامَنَ السُّفَهَاءُ أَلَا إِنَّهُمْ هُمُ السُّفَهَاءُ وَلَكِن لَّا يَعْلَمُونَ ١٤ وَإِذَا الْقَوَا أُولَئِكَ الَّذِينَ ءَامَنُوا قَالُوا ءَامَنَّا وَإِذَا خَلَوْا إِلَى شَيَاطِينِهِمْ قَالُوا إِنَّا مَعَكُمْ إِنَّمَا نَحْنُ مُسْتَهْزَؤُونَ ١٥ اللَّهُ يَسْتَهْزِئُ بِهِمْ وَيَمُدُّهُمْ فِي طُغْيَانِهِمْ يَعْمَهُونَ ١٦ أُولَئِكَ الَّذِينَ اشْتَرُوا الضَّلَالَةَ بِالْهُدَى فَمَا رِيحَتْ بِجَدَرَتِهِمْ وَمَا كَانُوا مُهْتَدِينَ ١٧ مَثَلُهُمْ كَمَثَلِ الَّذِي اسْتَوْقَدَ نَارًا فَلَمَّا أَضَاءَتْ مَا حَوْلَهُ ذَهَبَ اللَّهُ بِنُورِهِمْ وَتَرَكَهُمْ فِي ظُلُمٍ لَا يَبْصُرُونَ ١٨ صُمُّ بَعْضِكُمْ عَنِّي فَهُمْ لَا يَرْجِعُونَ ١٩

19 Or, like a storm from the sky, with darkness, thunder, and lightning. They place their fingers in their ears, as if to evade death by the thunder bolts. God thus encompasses the disbelievers. 20 The lightning intermittently snatches away their eyesight. Whenever it lights for them, they walk therein. And when it turns dark, they stand still. If God wills, He can deprive them of their hearing, and their sight. Surely, God is Omnipotent.

21 O mankind, you shall worship your Lord, who created you, and those before you, that you may be devout. 22 It is He Who rendered the earth habitable for you, and He rendered the sky a structure. He sends down water from the sky to produce fruits for your sustenance. Therefore, you shall not set up rivals to rank with God, despite this knowledge. 23 If you have any doubts concerning what We have revealed herein to our servant (Muhammad), then produce one sura like these, and invite your idols, whom you worship instead of God, to do the same, if you are right. 24 If you fail to do this, and most certainly you shall fail, then beware of the hellfire whose fuel shall be people and rocks. It awaits the disbelievers. 25 As for those who believe, and do good works, give them the good news that they shall enjoy Gardens with flowing streams. Whenever they are provided with fruits therein, they shall say, "This was provided for us previously." They shall be given similar provisions, and they shall have pure spouses therein. They shall abide therein eternally. 26 Thus, God is not ashamed to cite any kind of allegory, from as lowly as a mosquito, and higher. As for those who believe, they shall know that it is the truth from their Lord. As for those who disbelieve, they shall say, "What did God mean by such an allegory?" Thus, He misleads many thereby, and He guides many thereby. But he never misleads any thereby except the wicked.

أَوْ كَصَيْبٍ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ فِيهِ ظُلُمَاتٌ وَرَعْدٌ وَبَرْقٌ يَجْعَلُونَ أَصْصِعَهُمْ
فِيهِ إِذَا نَهَمَ مِنَ الصَّوْرِ عَلَى حَذَرِ الْمَوْتِ وَاللَّهُ مُحِيطٌ بِالْكَافِرِينَ ١٩
يَكَادُ الْبَرْقُ يَخْطَفُ أَبْصَرَهُمْ كُلَّمَا أَضَاءَ لَهُمْ مَشْوَافِهِمْ وَإِذَا
أَظْلَمَ عَلَيْهِمْ قَامُوا وَلَوْ شَاءَ اللَّهُ لَذَهَبَ بِسَمْعِهِمْ وَأَبْصَرِهِمْ إِنْ
أَلَّهَ عَلَى كُلِّ شَيْءٍ قَدِيرٌ ٢٠ يَا أَيُّهَا النَّاسُ اعْبُدُوا رَبَّكُمُ الَّذِي
خَلَقَكُمْ وَالَّذِينَ مِنْ قَبْلِكُمْ لَعَلَّكُمْ تَتَّقُونَ ٢١ الَّذِي جَعَلَ لَكُمُ
الْأَرْضَ قَرَارًا وَالسَّمَاءَ بِنَاءً وَأَنْزَلَ مِنَ السَّمَاءِ مَاءً فَأَخْرَجَ بِهِ مِنَ
الشَّجَرَاتِ رِزْقًا لَكُمْ فَلَا تَجْعَلُوا لِلَّهِ أَنْدَادًا وَأَنْتُمْ تَعْلَمُونَ ٢٢ وَإِنْ
كُنْتُمْ فِي رَيْبٍ مِمَّا نَزَّلْنَا عَلَى عَبْدِنَا فَأْتُوا بِسُورَةٍ مِثْلِهِ وَادْعُوا
شُهَدَاءَكُمْ مِنْ دُونِ اللَّهِ إِنْ كُنْتُمْ صَادِقِينَ ٢٣ فَإِنْ لَمْ تَفْعَلُوا وَلَنْ تَفْعَلُوا
فَاتَّقُوا النَّارَ الَّتِي وَقُودُهَا النَّاسُ وَالْحِجَارَةُ أُعِدَّتْ لِلْكَافِرِينَ ٢٤ وَبَشِّرِ
الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا وَعَمِلُوا الصَّالِحَاتِ أَنَّ لَهُمْ جَنَّاتٍ تَجْرِي مِنْ تَحْتِهَا الْأَنْهَارُ
كُلَّمَا رُزِقُوا مِنْهَا مِنْ ثَمَرٍ رِزْقًا قَالُوا هَذَا الَّذِي رُزِقْنَا مِنْ قَبْلُ وَأُتُوا
بِهِ مُتَشَابِهًا وَلَهُمْ فِيهَا أَنْوَاعٌ مُطَهَّرَةٌ وَهُمْ فِيهَا خَالِدُونَ ٢٥
* إِنْ أَلَّهَ لَا يَسْتَحْيِي أَنْ يَضْرِبَ مَثَلًا مَّا بَعُوضَةً فَمَا فَوْقَهَا فَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ آمَنُوا
فَيَعْلَمُونَ أَنَّهُ الْحَقُّ مِنْ رَبِّهِمْ وَأَمَّا الَّذِينَ كَفَرُوا فَيَقُولُونَ مَاذَا أَرَادَ اللَّهُ بِهَذَا
مَثَلًا يُضِلُّ بِهِ كَثِيرًا وَيَهْدِي بِهِ كَثِيرًا وَمَا يُضِلُّ بِهِ إِلَّا الْفَاسِقِينَ ٢٦

27 (The wicked ones) who break their covenant with God after accepting it, tear asunder what God had commanded to preserve, and corrupt the earth. Such are the losers. 28 How can you disbelieve in God? You were dead, and He granted you life; then He will put you to death; then He will bring you back to life; then to Him you shall be returned. 29 It is He who created for you everything on earth. Then He turned to the sky and fashioned seven heavens therein. He is Omniscient.

COMMENTARY

Sura Al-Baqarah was the first sura revealed in Medina. Its title, which means the heifer, refers to a very significant incident which is reported in verses 67-74; an incident wherein Moses proved to the Israelites that he did communicate with God; an incident wherein a murder victim was revived to point out his murderer, and thus a great sign was manifested to the Children of Israel. A distorted version of this incident appears in today's bibles. (Numbers 19:6)

The Letters A.L.M.:

The first verse of sura *Al-Baqarah* consists of three independent letters of the Arabic alphabet, namely, *Alif* (A), *Lām* (L), and *Mīm* (M). Throughout the Qur'an, there are 29 suras which are prefixed with such "initials." These Qur'anic initials are known as "openers of the suras" **قَوَائِمُ السُّورَاتِ**; "in the Western literature, they are called "the mysterious letters." The possible significance of these letters has been the subject of numerous theories in the past 14 centuries. There is a unanimous agreement in the literature that the significance of the Qur'anic initials has never been unveiled (3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12).

In the course of preparing this commentary, however, the Qur'anic initials were studied extensively with the help of electronic computers. By the grace of God, the possible role of the Qur'anic initials was at least partially uncovered. The data, the results, and the conclusions were so vast that they

الَّذِينَ يَنْقُضُونَ عَهْدَ اللَّهِ مِنْ بَعْدِ مِيثَاقِهِ وَيَقْطَعُونَ مَا أَمَرَ اللَّهُ بِهِ أَنْ
يُوصَلَ وَيُفْسِدُونَ فِي الْأَرْضِ أُولَٰئِكَ هُمُ الْخَاسِرُونَ ﴿٢٧﴾ كَيْفَ
تَكْفُرُونَ بِاللَّهِ وَكُنْتُمْ أَمْوَاتًا فَأَحْيَاكُمْ ثُمَّ تُمَيِّسُّكُمْ ثُمَّ يُحْيِيكُمْ ثُمَّ
إِلَيْهِ تُرْجَعُونَ ﴿٢٨﴾ هُوَ الَّذِي خَلَقَ لَكُمْ مَا فِي الْأَرْضِ جَمِيعًا ثُمَّ اسْتَوَىٰ إِلَى
السَّمَاءِ فَسَوَّاهُنَّ سَبْعَ سَمَوَاتٍ وَهُوَ بِكُلِّ شَيْءٍ عَلِيمٌ ﴿٢٩﴾

required an independent book (1). Thus, for a detailed study of the Qur'anic initials, the reader may refer to reference No. 1. This computerized study of the Qur'anic initials provided undisputable evidence that the Qur'an is the word of God; that it could never be written by a man, or any number of men, in the past, present, or future.

Since we are concerned here with the three Qur'anic initials *Alif* (A), *Lām* (L), and *Mīm* (M) of sura *Al-Baqarah*, the specific function of these letters is presented herein. It appeared from the detailed computerized study that the letters A.L.M. provide mathematical support for the system of recording the Qur'an (1). The frequency of occurrence of these 3 letters throughout the Qur'an indicates that the final form of Qur'an as we know it today is the divinely ordained form. Thus, it was found that the suras which contain these initials [Al-Baqarah (No. 2), Āli-'Imrān (No. 3), Al-'Ankabūt (No. 29), Al-Rūm (No. 30), Luqmān (No. 31), and Al-Sajdah (No. 32)] were required to be averaged together according to their continuity in the Qur'an, regardless of their revelation sequence, in order to observe their superiority with regard to the frequency of A, L, & M. It should be noted that the A.L.M.-initialed suras were revealed separately, but recorded consecutively. The opposite was true with regard to the letters A.L.R.; the A.L.R.-initialed suras were revealed consecutively, but recorded separately. The computerized study showed that while the Qur'anic initials A.L.M. serve to confirm the recorded sequence of Qur'an, the initials A.L.R. serve to confirm the authenticity of the revelation sequence. The indulgence of the reader is requested for presenting this extremely condensed explanation of the Qur'anic initials. For a full understanding of this discussion the reader may refer to the detailed study.

Linguistic Efficiency of the Qur'an

One of the miraculous literary phenomena of the Qur'an is the frequent occurrence of a verse which conveys a number of different meanings, simultaneously and without contradiction. In just the few verses which we are discussing here, two such verses occur. These are verse number 2 and verse number 7 of sura *Al-Baqarah*. Thus, verse 2 conveys the following two messages:

1. This Qur'an cannot be doubted in the least. There is no doubt in its authenticity; there is no doubt that it came from God. This meaning is obtained when we place a full stop after the word "doubt" **ذَٰلِكَ الْكِتَٰبُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيْهِ** = This scripture is without a doubt = there is no doubt that this is a divine scripture.
2. This Qur'an provides guidance for the righteous people who heed the message. Such meaning is obtained as we recite the same verse to the end, " **ذَٰلِكَ الْكِتَٰبُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيْهِ هُدًى لِّلْمُتَّقِيْنَ** .. **ذَٰلِكَ الْكِتَٰبُ لَا رَيْبَ فِيْهِ** this scripture is without a doubt; providing guidance for the righteous."

The reader will note that the English rendering was done in such a way to convey, as closely as possible, the same impression as that conveyed by the Arabic text upon the Arabic reader.

Similarly, we can simultaneously derive two compatible meanings from verse 7:

1. God seals the hearts of the disbelievers, and places *a veil on their hearing and their vision*.
2. God seals the hearts and the hearing of the disbelievers, and places a veil upon their vision.

This linguistic efficiency is unique to the Qur'an; it explains to us the deliberate omission of the punctuation marks therefrom.

Three Types of People:

Verses 3 through 20 of sura *Al-Baqarah* divide the people into three categories; the righteous, the heathens, and the hypocrites. It is significant that the righteous are described in three verses; the heathens are described in two verses, while the hypocrites are described in 13 verses. These facts reflect the subtleness of hypocrisy and the need to recognize it, especially within ourselves, and expose it.

Since the criteria are set so clearly and vividly in the Qur'an, no further comment is needed regarding the three categories of people. One can read the divine verses, and directly use them to find his place within these three categories. Thus, I cannot count myself among the righteous unless I fulfill

all the requirements set forth in verses 3 and 4, namely, belief in the unseen (God, the angels, the hereafter, etc), observing the five daily ṣalāt prayers, spending from God's provision (not hoarding), belief in and upholding the Qur'an, belief in and upholding all previous revelations, and certainty about resurrection. Unless I fulfill these six requirements, I will have to find my place within the other two categories, the heathens or the hypocrites. As we seek to find our place among these three categories, it is of vital importance that one must never defend his "self" or find excuses to absolve it. Those who do achieve salvation and discover the right *path* are those who can courageously accuse the self and never side with it. The prophet Muḥammad (God's blessings and peace be upon him) said in this respect, "Your most ardent enemy is your 'self' which resides within your body." (Al-Bukhārī) (13).

It should be noted that as a *consequence* of their decision, with their own free will, to reject God's guidance, the heathens and the hypocrites are rendered totally deaf, dumb, and blind to any divine admonition (verses 6, 7, 10, & 18). Thus, there is no way whereby anyone can convince them of the most obvious truths.

Moreover, verses 10 and 26 of sura Al-Baqarah (as well as numerous verses throughout the Qur'an) explicitly inform us that the rejectors of truth are actually led further and further from the truth by none other than the Almighty Himself. After exercising their absolute freedom, and after reaching a decision to reject God's truth, such rejectors are placed under circumstances which serve invariably to move them away from the right path. This fact is especially evident in the writings of the anti-Islam activists; one can see so clearly that they are always led into a maze of dead-end alleys where they remain hopelessly trapped.

In verses 21 and 22, mankind is enjoined to worship the Creator; Who created them and provided for them. As for the skeptics who refuse to give serious, objective thought to God's message, the Qur'an, they are handed a challenge to prove their claim that it is man-made. The challenge (verse 23) is coupled with an assurance that no one can possibly meet it (verse 24). The recent computerized study of the Qur'an, which provided physical evidence that the Qur'an could never be man-made, sheds a new light on the Qur'anic challenge explained here. By physical, examinable means, it is now proven that the miraculous composition of the Qur'an is not only literal, but also mathematical. For the reader who is not yet familiar with the computerized study of the Qur'an's alphabetical structure, let us take a simple example. Among the Qur'an's 114 suras, two are initialed with the letter *Qāf* (Q). These two suras are *Al-Shūrā* (No. 42) and *Qāf* (No. 50). Although sura *Al-Shūrā* is more than twice as long as sura *Qāf*, the

computer revealed that these two suras contain the same number of the letter *Qāf* (Q), namely 57 each. Considering that the Qur'an was revealed over a period of 23 years, and that the individual verses came down widely separated both in time and place, it becomes undeniably clear that the Qur'an is the word of God. No creature could ever possess advance knowledge of the mathematical distribution of the individual alphabetic letters throughout the Qur'an. This overwhelming evidence is physical, touchable, and examinable, since anyone anywhere in the world can count the letter *Qāf* in the two *Qāf*-initialed suras and find for himself or herself that they contain the same numbers of *Qāfs*, 57. Obviously, this number is not random. When we add the 57 *Qāfs* of sura Al-Shūrā to the 57 *Qāfs* of sura *Qāf*, we get 114, same number as the suras of Qur'an. Thus, if the letter "Q" stands for "Qur'an," the inescapable message is clear; that the 114 suras constitute God's message to humanity, the whole message, and nothing but the message.

This very small and very simple example from the computerized study of Qur'an is consistent with the divine statement in verse 24 regarding the impossibility of composing anything like the Qur'an by other than God Himself.

We come across the first description of heaven and hell in verses 24 and 25. Verse 24 describes hell as a fire whose fuel shall be people and rocks. Verse 25 describes heaven as gardens with flowing streams, fruits, and pure spouses. At the same time, we are told in verse 26 that these are allegorical descriptions; that heaven and hell are described in the Qur'an in terms we can comprehend; terms which the simplest, illiterate individuals, as well as the most educated ones, can appreciate and understand. The Prophet Muḥammad (may God bestow blessings and peace upon him) reiterated the spirit of verse 26 when he told us that heaven is something "no eye has ever seen, no ear has ever heard, and never imagined by a human being."

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